He also attributed the decision to acquire Corus to the synergy that could be developed between the two companies. He said that with Corus giving Tata Steel a ‘global reach in Europe and synergies with lost-cost intermediaries in India’, it was an attractive proposition. He also clarified that if Muthuraman had said that it ‘wouldn’t work, we would not have gone ahead’.

Investors and analysts on Dalal Street (India’s Wall Street), did not, however, celebrate the victory. Tata Steel shareholders were bewildered at the feistiness to grab the flailing Corus. There was a strong section that believed that Tata Steel had grossly overpaid for it. Wasn’t Corus too large for Tata Steel to digest; wouldn’t the 12-billion-dollar tab strangle Tata Steel’s domestic investment and growth plans; was this the right time to buy Corus; did Ratan allow his heart to rule over his head—these were some of the questions on people’s lips. Tata Steel shares tanked 10.7 per cent on 31 January. But Ratan believed that he had made the right deal. ‘In the future somebody will look back and say we did the right thing. Corus is a unique opportunity for us in terms of scale, location and culture. This is a key part of our global strategy,’ he said to *The Guardian*.

He rationalized the price Tata Steel had paid for the acquisition to the same newspaper in another interview: ‘After we expressed our interest in Corus, investors like hedge funds bought into the shares and drove the prices up on the markets. Would they agree to sell cheaper than what the market prices were? I think not.’ He added, ‘At 608 pence ($11.97), we hadn’t reached the limit we had set ourselves.’

Gandhi comments that the price was ‘very, very fair’. The year after the acquisition, Corus made about $300 million more than the year in which it was acquired, he recalls. He also adds that Tata Steel got an access to Europe through a great brand it now owned. It started exporting its products to the continent, which would not have been generally possible if it were not for the acquisition.

Soon after emerging as the winner of the bid, Ratan wrote to all the key persons who had assisted in the acquisition process. He wrote to Steinbruch as well, complimenting him for the ‘strategies’ he had ‘charted out for the acquisition’ as also for the ‘economic model’ he had built in CSN. He concluded the letter by inviting Steinbruch to visit India to ‘show’ him ‘a bit of our country’. He also wrote, ‘Unfortunately, we were not able to have two winners as we had hoped.’